

Jellyfish and anemones

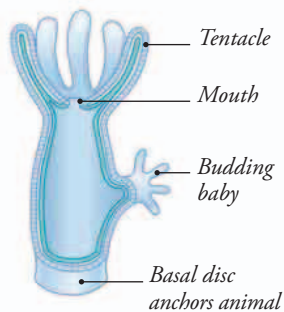
The jellyfish that swim gracefully through the oceans are part of a group of animals called cnidarians, which also include sea anemones and corals. These animals look very different from each other, but they have the same basic body structure, and they are armed with stinging cells, which they use to stun prey. They live in all oceans at all depths, but they are particularly common in shallow coastal seas.

GRACEFUL JELLYFISH

The most spectacular cnidarians are jellyfish, which live in open water. A jellyfish swims by squeezing its flexible body to force water out, then relaxing so the body springs back to its original shape. Its bell may have a fringe of tentacles, while bigger feeding arms surround its central mouth. Some jellyfish gather small edible particles, but others snare larger animals using batteries of stinging cells.

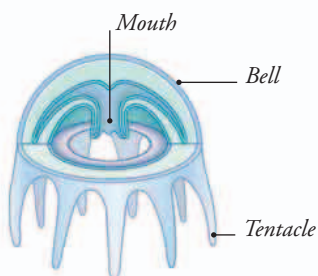
TUBES AND BELLS

All cnidarians have hollow circular or tubular bodies made of an outer and inner skin separated by a layer of jelly. The inner skin acts as a stomach lining. There are two forms: polyps and medusae. Tubular polyps such as anemones live anchored to rocks with their mouth and crown of stinging tentacles facing upward. By contrast, medusae such as jellyfish are umbrella-shaped, free-swimming animals that live with their mouths and tentacles facing downward.



▲ POLYP

A polyp is a tube of jelly glued to a rock. Some types of polyp multiply by growing smaller polyps from their sides.



▲ MEDUSA

An adult jellyfish is a medusa—a free-swimming cnidarian. Most jellyfish spend part of their lives as polyps, then become medusae.

Like many jellyfish, the mauve stinger can glow in the dark.



Four large feeding arms gather food into the central mouth

▲ MAUVE STINGER

This colorful jellyfish lives in all the warm and slightly cooler oceans of the world, where it feeds on other drifting animals. It has a painful sting.